I'm a hobby photographer. I'll send you two sets of photos, one at a time.
First my own photos, then reference photos I admire.
I want my photos to feel more like the reference photos.
Don't give advice yet. Just reply "Ready" and wait for my photos.

Ready



These are my photos (set 1). Don't give advice yet.
Just tell me how many photos you can see, and list their file names.

I can see **15 photos**, and the file names are:

1. RXM02200.jpg
2. RXM02723.JPG
3. RXM02820.JPG
4. DSC00562.JPG
5. DSC00695.JPG
6. DSC01343.JPG
7. DSC01668.jpg
8. DSC02000.JPG
9. IMG_0397.JPG
10. IMG_1062.JPG
11. IMG_1592.JPG
12. IMG_5544.JPG
13. IMG_8748.JPG
14. RXM01956.JPG
15. RXM02063.jpg

The file list doesn't map each name to a specific image, so I can't say which name belongs to which photo. If you want me to refer to individual shots later, I'll go by their position in the

order you uploaded them or by a short description.

Ready for your reference photos whenever you are.



These are the reference photos (set 2), the look I admire.
Now tell me what I should do differently when I'm shooting, so my photos get closer to this look.
Give me advice I can try on my next shoot.

Your best frames (the leaf macro, the cable bridge, the S-curve road) already share the reference look: directional light, strong shapes, rich color. The difference is that the references do this in nearly every frame, and many of your other shots rely on flat light and open space. Here is what to change on your next shoot.

1. Shoot in low, directional light

This is the biggest gap. The references are almost all golden hour: backlit maple leaves, warm side light raking across Matera's stone, the glowing Hogwarts at dusk. Many of your shots (the alpine trail, the safari plain, the Montreal street, the airplane) were taken in flat, hazy or midday light.

- Plan your key shots for the first 90 minutes after sunrise or the last 90 before sunset.
- Put the sun behind or beside your subject, not behind you.
- In hazy or overcast conditions, don't shoot wide landscapes. Switch to tight, detailed subjects like the leaf macro, where flat light is less of a problem.

2. Expose for the highlights and let shadows go dark

The references have deep, almost black shadows with glowing highlights (the pagoda, the cathedral light beam, the sunlit leaves). Your frames tend to be evenly lit and mid-toned.

- Use exposure compensation of about -0.7 to -1.3 EV when shooting into light.
- Check your histogram or highlight warnings and protect the brightest area (sun-lit leaf, glowing window), then let the rest fall off.
- Shoot RAW so you can lift shadows later if needed.

3. Frame through foreground

Nearly every reference has a dark foreground layer: branches in the beach shot, the stone arch in the Hogsmeade shot, leaves over the pagoda. This gives depth and makes the bright area pop. Your shots mostly go straight at the subject with open space around it.

- Look for branches, arches, doorways, railings or silhouetted people to shoot through.
- Get close to the foreground element and use a wide aperture so it blurs softly.

4. Use one small human figure, placed deliberately

The references use a single person as a focal point and scale cue: the woman at the pagoda's edge, the figure on the Capri wall, the dog walker under the maples. Your people are often a crowd, or tiny and scattered.

- Wait for one person to enter a clean part of the frame.
- Place them off-center on a light or color contrast, such as a bright jacket against dark foliage.
- Simplify the background around them.

5. Simplify and use a vertical frame

Most references are vertical and built around one idea. Your busier frames (the Montreal crowd, the Duluth harbor) have many competing elements.

- Before pressing the shutter, ask what the one subject is and remove or step around anything that isn't helping.
- Shoot vertical more often, especially for tall subjects or layered scenes.

6. Make color a deliberate pair

The references pair colors on purpose: teal and orange, blue sky and warm stone, red pagoda and green leaves, gold and deep blue. Your frames are often one dominant color (all blue, all green).

- Look for a warm subject against a cool background, or the reverse.
- A polarizing filter deepens skies and greens, and can help cut haze.
- Dusk is good for this: the blue sky and warm artificial lights give you the pairing for free.

7. Control depth of field

Some references use shallow focus, like the blurred woman in Matera and the bokeh in the puddle shot. Your telephoto shots mostly render everything sharp or hazy.

- Shoot at f/1.8 to f/4 when you want separation.
- Get closer to your subject and keep distance behind it.
- For lights at night, shoot wide open with the lights far behind your subject.

8. Use sun flares and reflections on purpose

The sun peeking through leaves, flares and reflections all appear in the references. You have some of this (the sun flare through the car window), but it looks accidental.

- For starbursts, stop down to about f/8 to f/11 and let the sun peek around an edge.
- Look for puddles, still water or glass, and get low to the ground for reflections.

9. Use elevated viewpoints for leading lines

The Capri path and the beach circles work because of the high angle and curving shapes. Your S-curve road and trail shots already do this. Go further by shooting from above with a telephoto to compress layers, and look for paths, rails or roads that curve through the frame.

A quick checklist for each shot

1. Where is the light coming from? Is it low and directional?
2. What is the one subject?
3. Is there something dark or soft in the foreground to frame it?
4. Is there a color contrast?
5. Did I expose for the highlights?

Some of the references have also been graded in editing, with boosted contrast, warm and teal tones and deepened shadows. But editing works much better when the light and composition are already right, and that's what these tips are about.

If you want, send me two or three of your shots and I'll tell you specifically how I'd reshoot each one.